

Travel and Expense Policy

Policy code: POL-FIN-007 | Owner: Group Finance | Effective date: 1 April 2024 | Version: 1

1. Purpose

This policy sets out how Meridian Instruments Ltd employees travel on company business and how they are reimbursed for reasonable expenses incurred while doing their job. It applies to all employees, contractors engaged through Meridian payroll and temporary staff at every Meridian site: Leeds, Rotterdam, Austin and Penang.

The principle behind the policy is simple. Spend Meridian's money as carefully as you would spend your own. Choose the most economical option that still allows you to do your work safely and effectively, and never make or receive a claim that you would not be comfortable explaining to a colleague in Finance.

2. Scope

This policy covers business travel (air, rail, road, taxis and hire cars), hotel accommodation, meals and daily subsistence, client entertainment, and other out-of-pocket business costs such as professional subscriptions and small purchases.

It does not cover the purchase of goods or services from suppliers, which must be raised as a purchase requisition under the Procurement Manual (POL-FIN-012) and approved in line with the Delegation of Authority and Approval Matrix (POL-FIN-003). Use of the Northgate Commercial Card is governed by the Corporate Card Policy (POL-FIN-009).

3. Before you travel

All travel must have a clear business purpose and be agreed in advance with your line manager. Consider whether a video call on Teams would achieve the same result before booking a trip.

International travel requires a completed International Travel Pre-Approval form (F-221). The form must be submitted at least 10 days before the planned departure date and approved by your budget holder. The form records the purpose of the trip, the estimated total cost and the cost centre to be charged. Travel booked without an approved F-221 may not be reimbursed.

Book flights, rail and hotels through the Travel module in Atlas, which connects to our travel management company. Step-by-step instructions are in the Travel Booking Guide. Bookings made outside Atlas are only reimbursed when the Atlas option was unavailable or demonstrably more expensive, and the reason must be stated on the claim.

4. Air travel

Class of travel is determined by the scheduled flight time of each individual flight, not the total journey time.

- Flights under 6 hours: economy class.
- Flights of 6 hours or more: premium economy class may be booked.
- Flights over 10 hours: business class may be booked with prior approval from the Finance Director.

Book at least 14 days ahead where possible and choose the lowest logical fare. Seat selection and one checked bag are reimbursable. Airline lounge memberships are not.

5. Rail travel

Standard class is the default for all rail travel. First class may be booked where the scheduled journey time exceeds 3 hours, or where an advance first class ticket is cheaper than the flexible standard fare. Railcards purchased for frequent business travel are reimbursable where they pay for themselves within the year.

6. Road travel and mileage

Use of a private car for business travel is reimbursed per unit of distance at the rates below. Commuting between home and your normal place of work is not business mileage. Mileage must be recorded on a Mileage Log (F-207) or entered in the mileage section of the Atlas claim, showing date, start point, destination, purpose and distance.

Country | Rate

UK | 45p per mile, first 10,000 miles
UK | 25p per mile, above 10,000 miles
Netherlands | €0.21 per km
United States | \$0.67 per mile
Malaysia | RM 0.80 per km

Employees who receive a car allowance under the Company Car and Car Allowance Policy (POL-FIN-015) should follow that policy for business mileage.

Hire cars should be compact or intermediate class and booked through Atlas. Refuel before returning the vehicle. Taxis and ride-hailing services are reimbursed where no reasonable public transport option exists, when carrying heavy equipment, or when travelling after 21:00.

7. Accommodation

Hotels should be booked through Atlas at or below the nightly cap for the city. Caps are per room per night and include breakfast where offered, but exclude local tourist taxes. Where a trade fair or major event means no room is available at the cap, the budget holder may approve a higher rate in advance.

8. Per-diem and hotel caps by city

The per-diem allowance covers meals and incidental expenses for a full day away from your home location with an overnight stay. On travel days where you depart after 12:00 or return before 12:00, half the per-diem applies. The per-diem is a cap on reimbursed actual spend supported by receipts, not a flat payment.

City | Per diem (meals) | Hotel cap per night

London | £55 | £180
Leeds | £40 | £110
Rotterdam | €50 | €150
Amsterdam | €60 | €190
Frankfurt | €60 | €170
Austin | \$60 | \$210
New York | \$85 | \$320
Penang | RM 150 | RM 400
Kuala Lumpur | RM 180 | RM 450
Singapore | SGD 90 | SGD 320

For cities not listed, use the rate for the nearest listed city in the same country, or ask expenses@meridian-instruments.example for guidance.

9. Expense category limits

Category | Limit

Team meal (manager-approved) | £25 per head
Working-late meal (after 20:00) | £15 per person
Client entertainment | £60 per head
Professional subscriptions | £300 per year
Business books and publications | £100 per year
Hotel laundry (trips over 5 nights) | £20 per trip
Mobile roaming add-ons | actual cost, pre-agreed

Limits for EUR, USD and MYR claims are converted at the Group budget exchange rate. Alcohol is only reimbursable as part of client entertainment and must be moderate. Client entertainment must be recorded with the names and organisations of all attendees. Gifts and hospitality given to or received from third parties must also be recorded where required by the Code of Conduct (POL-CORP-001).

10. Non-reimbursable items

- Fines, parking penalties and speeding tickets.
- Personal travel insurance (Meridian provides business travel cover).
- In-room films, minibar and spa charges.
- Upgrades bought with personal funds or loyalty points exchanged for cash.
- Expenses for partners or family members.
- Clothing and personal grooming.

11. Submitting a claim

Claims are submitted in Atlas under Atlas > Expenses > New Claim. Each claim must show the cost centre, the business purpose and, for meals and entertainment, the names of the people present.

Receipts are required for every item over £10 (or local equivalent). Photographs of receipts uploaded to Atlas are acceptable; keep the originals until the claim is paid. Card statements are not a substitute for a receipt.

Claims must be submitted within 90 days of the date the expense was incurred. Claims older than 90 days will be rejected unless the Group Financial Controller agrees an exception.

Reimbursement is paid through payroll. The cut-off dates for each site are published in the payroll calendars.

12. Approval thresholds

Each claim is routed for approval in Atlas according to its total value.

Claim total | Approver

Up to £500 | Line manager
£500.01 to £2,500 | Budget holder
Above £2,500 | Finance Director

No one may approve their own claim or a claim from someone to whom they report. Claims from members of the Executive team are approved by the CFO; claims from the CFO are approved by the CEO.

13. Compliance

Finance audits a sample of claims every month. Claims that breach this policy will be returned or reduced. Deliberately false or inflated claims are treated as gross misconduct under the Disciplinary and Grievance Procedure (POL-HR-040).

Questions about this policy should be sent to expenses@meridian-instruments.example.